Acoustical wonder of Golconda fort (Hyderabad, Telangana)

The Clapping portico in Golconda Fort is a series of arches on one side, each smaller than the preceding one. So, a sound wave generated under the dome would get compressed and then bounce back amplified sufficiently to reach a considerable distance.

5.2.2 Reflection at the boundary of a denser medium

A longitudinal wave travels in a medium in the form of compressions and rarefactions. Suppose a compression travelling in air from left to right reaches a rigid wall. The compression exerts a force F on the rigid wall. In turn, the wall exerts an equal and opposite reaction R = – F on the air molecules. This results in a compression near the rigid wall. Thus, a compression travelling towards the rigid wall is reflected back as a compression. That is the direction of compression is reversed (Figure 5.5).

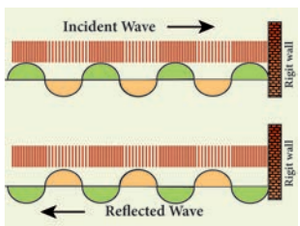
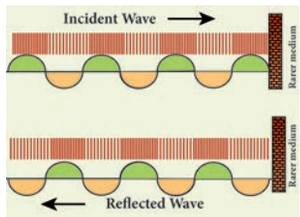


Figure 5.5 Reflection of sound at a denser medium

5.2.3 Reflection at the boundary of a rarer medium

Consider a wave travelling in a solid medium striking on the interface between the solid and the air. The compression exerts a force F on the surface of the rarer medium. As a rarer medium has smaller resistance for any deformation, the surface of separation is pushed backwards (Figure 5.6). As the particles of the rarer medium are free to move, a rarefaction is produced at the interface. Thus, a compression is reflected as a rarefaction and a rarefaction travels from right to left.



5.6 Reflection of sound at a rarer medium

More to know:

What is meant by rarer and denser medium?
The medium in which the velocity of sound increases compared to other medium is called rarer medium. (Water is rarer compared to air for sound).
The medium in which the velocity of sound decreases compared to other medium is called denser medium. (Air is denser compared to water for sound)

5.2.4 Reflection of sound in plane and curved surfaces

When sound waves are reflected from a plane surface, the reflected waves travel in a direction, according to the law of reflection. The intensity of the reflected wave is neither decreased nor increased. But, when the sound waves are reflected from the curved surfaces, the intensity of the reflected waves is changed. When reflected from a convex surface, the reflected waves are diverged out and the intensity is decreased. When sound is reflected from a concave surface, the reflected waves are converged and focused at a point. So the intensity of reflected waves is concentrated at a point. Parabolic surfaces are used when it is required to focus the sound at a particular point. Hence, many halls are designed with parabolic reflecting surfaces. In elliptical surfaces, sound from one focus will always be reflected to the other focus, no matter where it strikes the wall.

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